

The casting of James Stewart affects the direction and impact of the movie profoundly; it adds an extra textual layer of dissonance to the final act. Stewart's image as an actor since the days of his early career, including previous roles for Hitchcock in *Rear Window* (1954) and *The Man Who Knew Too Much* (1956), had always been that of the incorruptible everyman, decent and likeable to a fault. John "Scottie" Ferguson begins as a good man, a typical Stewart character, but ends it as a man lost in sexual despair, his mind ruined by tragedy. By putting James Stewart through this transformation, Hitchcock is not just undoing a man, he's undoing a screen icon. What we think we know of Stewart's character makes Ferguson's psychosis that much more painful to watch, and his unraveling affects us that much more deeply. The visual representation of this

Scottie and Madeleine (Kim Novak) first embrace after she has asked him whether she is crazy. Judy, as Madeleine, has fallen for Scottie, and it is this that will ultimately lead to her downfall.

process is never more clear than in a dream sequence that sees Stewart's disembodied head spiraling down into an abyss. His usual clean-cut image is distorted as a wind unsettles his hair and his expression. He looks lost.

Twisted thriller

Vertigo is an expertly crafted thriller, but one with twisted perspectives. The villain's murderous

plan succeeds, the love story is poisoned by lies, and the protagonist is broken emotionally and physically. It is arguably the darkest movie the director ever made. It is a Hitchcock movie with no Hollywood obligations, as the director seeks a richer form of terror—not simply to shock,

repulse, or unsettle the audience, but to disturb them, to take everything they think they know about his style of filmmaking and to corrupt it to reveal something new.

In *Vertigo*, Hitchcock bares a little bit more of his soul so that he can twist the knife a little bit deeper. ■



Minute by minute

